

CONTRACT

on

Funding the Project:

Nordic Circular Hotspot transition groups 2025-2026

Project No.: P25013

Case number: 201-2503-P25013

Between;

Norden Nordic Innovation
Stensberggata 27, NO-0170 Oslo, Norway
(hereinafter called **Nordic Innovation**)

And;

Nordic Circular Hotspot AS,
St Halvards Gate 33, 0192 Oslo, Norway

(hereinafter called the **Contracting Partner**)

in connection to;

The Program:

201 - Innovative Solutions for 2030

(hereinafter called the Program)

Nordic Innovation and the Contracting Partner are individually designated as the Party and collectively as the Parties.

1.0 The Project

The Project is described in Attachment 2.

2.0 The Contract

The Contract includes:

- This Contract Document
- Attachment 1 - Standard Terms and Conditions of Contract, dated 4 June 2020:
www.nordicinnovation.org/termsandconditions
- Attachment 2 – The Project Application ((8 August and) 8 September 2025)

3.0 The Aim of the Contract

This Contract regulates the Parties' rights and obligations pursuant to the implementation of the project P25013 (hereinafter referred to as the Project).

4.0 The Project Funding

The funding is granted on the conditions and the plans stated in this Contract with its Attachments.

Nordic Innovation's allocation for P25013 amounts to a total sum of maximum NOK 1 500 000 for the Project Period starting on 8 August 2025 and ending on 31 July 2026.

Disbursement will be done according to Art. 2.2. of [the Standard terms and Conditions of Contract](#).

Invoices to Nordic Innovation shall be sent by EHF, organization number 971516577, or electronically by tif- or pdf- format to the following email address: 971516577@autoinvoice.no

The invoice must contain the following info on the invoice:

- Case number 201-2503-P Nordic Circular Hotspot Transition groups 2025-2026
- Contact person Hanna Törmänen and Peter Munch-Madsen
- Contact person at Nordic Circular Hotspot
- The invoice must contain the senders bank account number, including IBAN and SWIFTs numbers for foreign companies.

5.0 SPECIAL terms and conditions

The project and transition groups should link and work with other ongoing Nordic Innovation initiatives to ensure synergies and maximum impact.

Communication on the project and the project results is important and should be widely spread. COMs should be coordinated with NI communication team.

Nordic Innovation shall be invited to attend all digital and physical events during the Project period.

Nordic Innovation's logo must be visible and the role as a financier shall be made apparent in the communication material related to the Project.

Nordic Innovation has the right to request information for communication purposes.

6.o Applicable law and dispute resolution

This Contract is governed by and shall be interpreted in accordance with Norwegian law. Any disputes arising in connection with this Contract shall be settled by Oslo District Court, unless otherwise agreed between the Parties.

7.o Entry into force

This agreement shall enter into force upon signature of both parties.

A signed copy shall be submitted to Nordic Innovation no later than 21 days from the date of the signature of Nordic Innovation. Failing to do so this contract shall be null and void.

8.o Contact Persons

Contact Person(s) - **Nordic Innovation:**

Hanna Törmänen

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Contact Person - **Contracting Partner: Nordic Circular Hotspot AS**

Einar Kleppe Holthe

phone: +47986 00 718 / email: einar@naturalstate.no

Place/date: Oslo, 07 October 2025

Nordic Innovation

Sindre Stemshaug Bornstein, Managing Director

Place/date:

Einar Kleppe Holthe

Nordic Circular Hotspot, Managing Partner



PROJECT INFORMATION	
Project title:	Nordic Circular Hotspot 2025
Project period:	From 2025-08-01 to 2026-06-15
Topic:	Nordic Circular Transition Groups x 4
Total amount applied for:	NOK 1 500 000
Project Owner:	Nordic Circular Hotspot AS
Contact Person:	Einar Kleppe Holthe
Address and country:	0192 Oslo, Norway
Phone and e-mail:	+47 98 60 07 18, enar@naturalstate.no
Project Partner:	Lifestyle and Design Cluster
Contact Person:	Betina Simonsen
Address and country:	Birk Centerpark 38, 7400 Herning, Danmark
Phone and e-mail:	+45 29 36 00 90, betina@ldcluster.com
Project Partner:	Cradlenet
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Address and country:	Badstrandsvägen 28, 112 65 Stockholm, Sweden
Phone and e-mail:	+46 70 635 46 46, michel@cradlenet.se
Project Manager:	Natural State AS
Contact Person:	Einar Kleppe Holthe
Address and country:	0192 Oslo, Norway
Phone and e-mail:	+47 98 60 07 18, enar@naturalstate.no

Executive summary (1/3 page)

Give a short introduction of the project and the overall purpose ("the elevator pitch"). The summary may be published on Nordic Innovation website and social media channels.

This application covers the initiation and execution of four Circular Transition Groups in collaboration with stakeholders in four contexts: **cities, corporations, food, and textile**. The purpose is to explore applicable relevant strategies for each context, write and publish a strategic roadmap based on the findings, and plan how to further evolve insights to action.

The **Nordic Circular Hotspot** is one of the driving forces to accelerate the transition to a circular and sustainable economy in the region by facilitating cross-sector and cross-national collaboration between stakeholders in Denmark, Finland, Iceland, Norway, Sweden. Our mission is to raise awareness and communicate knowledge and opportunities about the circular transition with the aim to inspire, initiate, and implement necessary action for the shift from a linear to a circular economy in the Nordics and beyond.

Our efforts are grounded in a strategic understanding of the Nordic business landscape and its challenges, weaknesses, and, most importantly, the vast opportunities for **sustainable value creation by implementing circular economy principles in value chains, sectors and industries in our joint market**.

The Nordic region consists of 5 countries, 3 autonomous regions, multiple indigenous societies, and 28 million citizens. Together we are the 12th biggest economy in the world.

A. Impact

Project objectives *(1 1/2 pages)*

PROBLEM, CHALLENGE, OBJECTIVES

i) What specific problem or challenge will the project solve? Give a short introduction of the main objectives, both short term (output) and long term (outcome and impact) of the project. Refer also to societal challenges (e.g. SDGs).

The planetary crisis on **climate, biodiversity and pollution** can be radically mitigated by a transition to a **circular economy**. The emissions of CO₂-equivalents alone may be reduced by half (~50%!) if we succeed in switching to circular production and consumption. By keeping resources (materials, components, products) in the loop for longer, we avoid emitting greenhouse gas caused by the energy needed to extract resources, prepare materials, manufacture, and transport products. By reducing extraction of virgin resources we reduce pollution, alleviate pressure on ecosystems, and promote biodiversity. Natural resources and thereby circular transition are directly linked to 13 of the 17 SDGs.

The circularity of the Nordic countries is low: at 3–4% it is far below the low median for European countries as calculated in various Circular Gap Reports. The awareness about and ambitions for the circular economy varies between the Nordic countries and sectors. Most initiatives and policy efforts are managed nationally in silo-structures.

The purpose of the Nordic Circular Hotspot is to accelerate the circular transition in the Nordics by engaging cross-sector and cross-national collaboration between stakeholders in the Nordics and beyond. Our mission is to raise awareness and communicate knowledge and opportunities about the circular transition with the aim to inspire, initiate and implement necessary action for the shift from a linear to a circular economy in the Nordic region.

The topics that are addressed in this application for Circular Transition Groups include **cities and corporations** which are two cross-sectoral meta-contexts with enormous impact. **Food and textile** are two of the value-chains with the largest average individual footprints across almost all SDGs. The purpose is to explore applicable relevant strategies for each context, compile and publish a strategic roadmap based on the findings, and shape a plan for how to further evolve insights to action. *Please see ANNEX 2 & 3 for a detailed description of project objectives and action plans for each group.*

LONG TERM GOALS *(generally for the Nordics and specifically for the four contexts)*

Awareness.	<u>Increase general awareness</u> of circular economy in the Nordics
Exchange.	<u>Stimulate exchange of knowledge</u> , innovations, solutions, technology, & best practices for transition
Solutions.	<u>Showcase circular solutions</u> regionally in the Nordics and beyond
Investments.	<u>Enable circular investments</u> by connecting investors with innovators, inventors, entrepreneurs
Symbiosis.	<u>Encourage industrial symbiosis</u> , locally and regionally between Nordic countries and other nations
Politics.	<u>Align political leadership</u> to collaborate, explore policies, and to contribute to circular Nordic goals
Goals.	<u>Align goals and targets</u> for the circular economy in the Nordics
Mainstream.	<u>Champion efforts</u> to make the circular economy the “new normal” in the Nordics
Market.	<u>Facilitate the creation of</u> a dynamic and functional circular market in the Nordics by 2030
Leadership.	<u>Establish the Nordics</u> as the leading circular hotspot regionally and internationally.

SHORT TERM GOALS

ii) How will the problems be solved?

The main activities of the project are organized in the 6 work packages specified in the table below.

iii). How will sustainability of the project results and impact creation after the project has ended be ensured (exit strategy)?

See WP1–WP4 below. A contextually relevant plan for the continuation and extended activities will be discussed with the stakeholders within each Transition Group.

WORK PACKAGES	CONTINUOUS WORK & MILESTONES	
WP1 # TG # Nordic Circular Cities. Catalyzes systemic change in Nordic urban areas by embedding circular principles into city planning, governance, and value creation. The group explores strategies that can empower municipalities to shift from linear to circular systems by integrating natural, human, and societal values into urban development. The ultimate aim of this TG is to support municipalities and industries by defining applicable frameworks and methodologies. This TG promotes new business opportunities, drives sustainable growth, and accelerates the Nordic region's leadership in circular urban living.	M1	• recruit and engage relevant stakeholders
	M2	• define a contextually relevant plan for activities within the TG
	M3	• execute workshops and other relevant activities
	M4	• write a strategic roadmap that summarizes key insights
	M5	• publish the roadmap and present results in public online event
	M6	• discuss possible next steps and make plan for further action
WP2 # TG # Nordic Circular Business. Accelerates the shift to circular business models across Nordic industries by embedding circular principles into corporate strategy, operations, and value creation. The group explores strategies, actions, frameworks, and governance models that can enable companies to initiate incremental change towards systemic circular transformation. The ultimate aim (<i>beyond the scope of this application</i>) is to equip Nordic companies with actionable pathways to integrate circularity into supply chains, product design, and service innovation. This TG drives competitiveness, promotes sustainable innovation, and strengthens the Nordics as a global leader in circular and resilient business practices.	M7	• recruit and engage relevant stakeholders
	M8	• define a contextually relevant plan for activities within the TG
	M9	• execute workshops and other relevant activities
	M10	• write a strategic roadmap that summarizes key insights
	M11	• publish the roadmap and present results in public online event
	M12	• discuss possible next steps and make plan for further action
WP3 # TG # Nordic Circular Food Systems. Accelerates the transformation of the Nordic food sector by addressing its reliance on imported feed and unlocking the potential of circular alternatives. The group gathers food producers, sellers, institutions, and public stakeholders to co-develop solutions that valorize side streams, promote regional feed innovation, and reduce food loss and waste. The ultimate aim of this TG is to map key value chains, analyze material flows, and identify scalable circular interventions across the food system. This TG fosters circular business development, enhances food security, and helps the development of sustainable and self-sufficient food systems in the Nordics.	M13	• recruit and engage relevant stakeholders
	M14	• define a contextually relevant plan for activities within the TG
	M15	• execute workshops and other relevant activities
	M16	• write a strategic roadmap that summarizes key insights
	M17	• publish the roadmap and present results in public online event
	M18	• discuss possible next steps and make plan for further action
WP4 # TG # Nordic Circular Textile. Drives the transformation of the Nordic textile and fashion sector by embedding circular principles into design, production, consumption, and post-use systems. The group explores strategies, frameworks, and collaborative models that can support industry actors in phasing out linear practices and scaling regenerative, circular value chains. The ultimate aim of this TG is to equip Nordic textile companies with practical pathways for circular design, extended producer responsibility, reuse infrastructure, and material innovation. This TG supports sustainable growth, promotes cross-sectoral collaboration, and strengthens the Nordic development of circular textile systems.	M19	• recruit and engage relevant stakeholders
	M20	• define a contextually relevant plan for activities within the TG
	M21	• execute workshops and other relevant activities
	M22	• write a strategic roadmap that summarizes key insights
	M23	• publish the roadmap and present results in public online event
	M24	• discuss possible next steps and make plan for further action
WP5 # Communication. Continuous promotion of activities and dissemination of insights in relevant channels and digital events. Cost for contextual and stakeholder-driven communication and dissemination is included (10–20%) in the budget of each TG above.	M25	• communicate activities and insights continuously in relevant channels
WP6 # Administration. Continuous administration and support of project related activities with regard to method, contacts, relevant IT-services, etc.	M26	• biweekly meetings for Steering Committee
	M27	• continuous administration
	M28	• continuous support of the TGs

Target group(s) (1/2 page)

Describe the target group(s) of the project and the reasons why they are targeted.

The Nordic Circular Hotspot primarily seeks to engage stakeholders from business, government, academia, and civil society that are relevant for the Transition Groups. These may be further detailed as follows:

Business: public and private companies of all sizes, trade organizations, industry associations, chambers of commerce, etc

National government: ministries, agencies, and all other relevant state-controlled bodies and networks

Local government: cities, regions, and all other types of bodies controlled by local or regional government and networks

Academia: universities and all other related organizations, bodies, and networks

Research & Development: other innovation-driving entities that does not clearly fit in any category above

Civil Society: think-tanks, associations, citizen-driven initiatives, social innovators, etc

International government: Nordic embassies abroad, foreign embassies in the Nordics, and related bodies and networks

Summary of current stakeholders in the NCH network from all categories:

Nordic Circular Hotspot committed Partners	94
Fee-based Partners	8
Fee-omitted Partners with effort and time.	86
Time committed on Nordic Collaborate Circular Economical Agenda. Hours of engagement per 2024.	4700
Newsletter subscribers <i>(overlaps with above)</i>	>6 000
Nordic Circular Summit Visitors <i>(overlaps with above)</i>	>2 500
LinkedIn Followers <i>(overlaps with above)</i>	11 534

Nordic added value (1/2 page)

What is the added value of conducting the project at a Nordic level?

The purpose of the Nordic Circular Hotspot is to accelerate the circular transition by engaging cross-national and cross-sector collaboration between stakeholders in the Nordics and beyond. The Transition Group-model is the key strategy and essence of the NCH theory of change. We believe that this type of collaboration may yield far greater value than the sum of the individual participants and their respective knowledge and actions.

The activities of NCH will promote and facilitate:

- *cross-border and cross-industry collaboration for circular transition and synergies within value chains*
- *coordination of circular activities among key stakeholders*
- *breaking down barriers for circular business models*
- *generation and sharing of knowledge and best practices*
- *the creation of an accessible Nordic circular market*
- *connecting capital, talent, and solutions*

Participating companies gain increased presence and visibility among potential partners and customers on the Nordic market. Stakeholders that engage early may be identified as frontrunners of the transition within their value chains.

B. Quality and Relevance

Background and relevance (1 page)

Who initiated this project and why?

The Nordic Circular Hotspot was initiated in 2018 by Nordic participants at the Holland Circular Economy Week out of mutual frustration over the lack of representation from Nordic political leaders. The founders were: *Betina Simonsen, Lifestyle and Design Cluster & National Circular Economy Hub (Denmark); Elin Bergman, Cradlenet (Sweden); Josefin Sallén, RISE (Sweden); Cathrine Barth, Circular Norway (Norway).*

The initial funding was provided by Nordic Innovation and Vinnova. In 2020 Natural State (Norway) joined. Nordic Innovation has continuously co-financed NCH efforts on a yearly basis 2021–2024. During these years, the group of managing partners was extended by *Business Finland, Danish Design Centre, Ethica (Finland), Festa (Iceland), Circular Solutions (Iceland), Lifestyle & Design Cluster, and RE:Source (Sweden). Wholistiq (Netherlands)* also participated in the initial years.

How will this project create something unique and innovative?

In this project we focus on collaborative explorative studies of circular transition in four contexts: cities, corporations, food systems, and textile. NCH is managed by the organizations and institutions with top expertise on circular transition. The premise is simple: under the umbrella of an inclusive and democratic non-profit organization, all relevant stakeholders are invited to engage in sharing best practices, solutions and to collaborate on cross-disciplinary circular transition plans for value chains.

What will be the significance and benefit of this project for sustainable growth, increased entrepreneurship, innovation and competitiveness for Nordic companies? The four Transition Groups offer an efficient model to facilitate collaborative explorative studies of how to achieve sustainable innovation and growth with a competitive edge across the region. Our vision is for the Nordic region to lead the global circular transition by example: driving change and creating lasting value for businesses and society. We work towards this vision in practice together with relevant stakeholders for each context.

Business plan and opportunities (1 page)

What is the market demand for the project results? What is the current development stage of your innovation/solution?

There is a rapidly increasing demand for collaboration, knowledge, and solutions for the circular transition in the Nordics and in Europe. The demand will continue to grow as a consequence of the rapid development of legislation by the EU regulating numerous aspects of material flows and circularity. The demand for tangible and applicable strategies and solutions within the four contexts which are subject for exploration in this application is particularly emphasized, as is evident from current debate on policy, numerous reports, and media coverage on sustainability.

What is the potential for value creation of the solution, for the businesses participating and Nordic businesses in general?

VALUE FOR PARTICIPANTS

Resource efficiency and cost savings. NCH promotes efficient use of resources that contribute to a decrease in raw material and energy costs that lead to significant cost savings for participating businesses.

Competitive advantage by sustainability. NCH encourages participating companies to explore circular business models and develop new sustainable products and services that appeal to an increasingly eco-conscious market.

New markets and revenue streams. NCH connects companies that explore circular business models with potential partners and customers on new geographic markets with associated revenue streams.

Branding and customer loyalty. NCH may ultimately, in practice and by association, enhance the brand reputation of participating companies that adopt circular practices.

VALUE FOR THE REGION

Circular collaboration. NCH facilitates cross-disciplinary cross-border collaborations where companies of all sizes join forces with academia and government to meet challenges in the circular transition across industries and value chains.

Economic development. A circular economy combines resilience, sustainability, and profitability. Keeping resources in transactional loops is highly beneficial for economies (local, national, regional), a climate-resilient sustainable development, and job creation in new green sectors.

Policy and regulations. The collective voice of NCH and its stakeholders may influence policy and regulatory frameworks to support circular practices and enhance the business environment for circular initiatives.

The Nordic brand. NCH ultimately seeks to elevate the Nordic brand globally, building on the Nordic region's reputation for environmental leadership, further associating it with innovation, sustainability, and high-quality circular solutions with a potential to attract international investment and partnerships.

Who are the end-users of the project results?

The Nordic Circular Hotspot is a market-development project in the shape of a multi-stakeholder platform for sustainable circular solutions. The direct end users are the participating companies and organizations in the Transition Groups. The macro-level beneficiaries are the Nordic nations and on a micro-level their citizens.

C. Competence and implementation (max 2 pages)

Outline who the different partners are, the working model, and the role and responsibility of each party in the implementation of the project and/or the results of the project. Describe the implementation capacity and competency of the consortium. Plan of Action. The involvement of Nordic businesses and industries must be described.

Background. The Nordic Circular Hotspot was initiated in 2019 and has since been developed by the founders and managing partners from Denmark, Finland, Iceland, Norway and Sweden with support from Nordic Innovation.

CONSORTIUM

The NCH Consortium for 2025 consists of a limited group of founders and managing partners that will be sharing responsibilities for operating the project and the legal entity owning the initiative this year.

Nordic Circular Hotspot AS. Owns the IPR and all other assets of the Nordic Circular Hotspot and is the project owner. The shares of this non-profit company are temporarily held by Natural State AS. The ownership is to be distributed according to the long-term model for ownership and governance as agreed by founders and managing partners.

Denmark **Lifestyle and Design Cluster (LDC)** is an innovation network with a strong circular economy profile that is building bridges between enterprises and research and knowledge institutions in Denmark.

Norway **Natural State AS** is a strategic development company that works with a holistic perspective of realization of ideas in an aware market where sustainability is the preferred long-term goal.

Sweden **Cradlenet** is a non-partisan and non-profit circular think tank and service organization for its corporate members dedicated to accelerating the circular transition in Sweden and beyond.

These well-renowned organizations will contribute and dedicate their top senior experts and management resources for the management and implementation of the project.

WORKING MODEL & RESPONSIBILITIES

Steering Committee. The Consortium members synchronize efforts, report progress, discuss new ideas and make decisions on changes and engagements. The chair is to be rotated among Consortium members for each meeting. The Steering Committee will essentially function as a board. Each decision will demand consensus of the group.

The Consortium is represented in the Steering Committee by: Michel Bajuk (Cradlenet), Einar Holthe (Natural State AS), and Betina Simonsen (Lifestyle and Design Cluster). The Steering Committee delegates responsibilities to the WP Leads.

Virtual Secretariat. NCH is managed by a geographically distributed team.

WP Lead. The various work packages (Transition Groups) are to be led by the respective assigned WP Leads.

Project Manager. The Consortium, project, and the Virtual Secretariat is managed by the Project Manager for this Consortium. For 2025 the project will be managed by Natural State with assistance from Cradlenet and LDC.

Staff & Resources. All funded and in-kind resources are to be managed by the Project Manager. Similarly, the WP Leads may manage attributed resources within the respective work packages. All WP Leads and staff employed by Consortium members and any other contributing associates and partners are, within the boundaries of committed and allocated time (%FTE, hours, and/or committed deliverables) to NCH, to report to and submit to instructions by the Project Manager or collective decisions by the Steering Committee. Simply put: all committed staff and resources are to be regarded as consultants providing a service to NCH. This does not change the legal responsibilities of each organization as employers.

INVOLVEMENT

The entire purpose of NCH is to facilitate cross-sector and cross-national collaboration between stakeholders in the Nordics and beyond. NCH currently has 94 partner organizations and several other companies and other organizations that are engaged in Circular Transition Groups. The participating organizations represent a wide variety of industries and interests across the Nordics. We aim to grow the number of participating organizations and extend possibilities to participate in and influence NCH activities.

ACTION PLAN

See table with specification of work packages and milestones above.

D. Budget and value for money

The budget must be specified for each partner in the consortium.

Budget: **NOK 3 000 000** of which we ask Nordic Innovation to cover **NOK 1 500 000** while the Consortium cover the remaining cost as in-kind efforts. Please see the appendix for the budget distribution per partner.

	NORDIC INNOVATION	CONSORTIUM
WP1 # TG # Nordic Circular Cities Enables municipalities to transition from linear to circular urban development. Supports systemic change through practical frameworks that drive innovation and sustainable growth.	250 000	250 000
WP2 # TG # Nordic Circular Business Supports Nordic industries in embedding circularity into strategy and operations. Focuses on scalable pathways for businesses to adopt sustainable models and strengthen resilience across value chains.	500 000	500 000
WP3 # TG # Nordic Circular Food Systems Reduces dependency on imported feed and food waste by promoting circular innovations in production and consumption. Connects key food system actors to co-create scalable, regionally rooted solutions.	250 000	250 000
WP4 # TG # Nordic Circular Textile Transforms the textile sector by phasing out linear models and advancing circular design, reuse, and material innovation. Equips Nordic companies with tools to scale regenerative textile value chains.	500 000	500 000
WP5 # Communications. Continuous promotion of activities and dissemination of insights. The cost is included (10–20%) in the budget of each TG above.	0	0
WP6 # Administration. Continuous administration and support of project related activities. Cost (10%) is included in the budget of each TG above.	0	0
Σ	NOK 1 500 000	NOK 1 500 000

Risk assessment (3/4 page)

Describe main risks that might jeopardize the success of the project and the consortium's mitigation plan?

Resource Constraints. Participating stakeholders may be stretched across multiple initiatives or face changes in internal priorities, reducing their availability to actively contribute in workshops and other activities. *Action: clarify expected contributions up front, maintain regular communication, and ensure flexible and time-efficient formats for engagement that prioritize early wins and visible results and value to participants.*

Fragmented Conditions. Differences in national priorities, regulatory frameworks, and sectoral agendas across Nordic countries may challenge alignment and slow collaboration between participants. *Action: establish clear governance structures, shared objectives, and transparent communication protocols to ensure alignment throughout the process.*

"Competition". Other networks, initiatives or organizations may pursue their own explorative studies of the topics included in this application. *Action: we consider any overlap with the Transition Groups as supplementary and synergetic rather than competitive: the more knowledge and engagement is generated, the better.*

Gender and diversity (1/3 page)

Describe how aspects of gender and diversity are dealt with in the project (e.g. accessibility).

Participation. NCH is a collaborative initiative that is open for participation for all Nordic companies and other types of organizations who wish to participate in the acceleration of the circular transition in the Nordics. We are committed to an inclusive environment. We facilitate free expression and democratic principles. We aim for the participating entities to reflect all aspects of diversity of the Nordic countries.

Management. We seek a diverse Nordic representation and a gender balance within our team. We promote dignity and respect for all. We encourage equality, diversity and inclusion and we recognize and value individual differences and the contributions. We foster a respectful work environment free of bullying, harassment, and victimization.

Employees & Associates. Our organizations share values. We respect the free will, identity and individuality of all and we aim for each employee to feel respected. We oppose discrimination and unequal employment opportunities based on age, disability, gender expression or identity, sexual orientation, culture, ethnicity, religion, belief, nationality, or any other aspect not related to merits and professional capacities. Complaints by employees, customers, suppliers, the public and others in the course of our operations are seriously considered and investigated.

Challenge. In general there is an overweight of female participation and engagement across most NCH-related activities. This reflects the overweight of female representatives in sustainability-related professions and roles.

Accessibility. We follow WCAG in the choice of systems for communication and outreach. We assure physical accessibility in the choice of venues for our physical events.

Communication (1/2 page)

Describe how the project and its results will be disseminated or given visibility.

NCH regularly publishes updates about activities, opportunities, success stories and insights via its relevant channels:

Websites:	nordiccircular #hotspot.org, #summit.com, arena.com
Social:	NCH has accounts on LinkedIn and FaceBook
Forum:	LinkedIn (+Arena to be decommissioned)
Newsletter:	monthly distribution to all listed subscribers and stakeholders
E-mail lists:	event visitors, stakeholders, partners, etc
Events:	Nordic Circular Summit, monthly partner meetings, webinars, etc
Streaming:	all events are available for viewing by participants via our video platform

Campaigns will be launched across relevant channels to market events, activities and publications. Virtual and, if/when feasible, physical events serve as platforms for communicating insights and results. All events are broadcasted online, thereby enhancing accessibility and participation for partners and external stakeholders. A high visibility is critical to engage a broad audience, reach mission targets and achieve impact:

Outreach:	NCH has accumulated significant and growing volumes of followers on various interests.
Search rank:	a search for "Nordic circular" lists the main webpage of Nordic Circular Hotspot in the top position.

Engaging our audience and community through surveys and interactive Q&A sessions enhances visibility and provides valuable insights for project refinement. Being responsive to the feedback from an active and engaged community helps us keep the project relevant to the needs of its stakeholders.

Annexes

1. Budget (NI template)	see attached
2. Transition Groups (description of goals and partners)	see below
3. Action Plan (with key deliverables and milestones)	see below

ANNEX 2 # TRANSITION GROUPS

The key objective of the project is to develop strategic roadmaps for the Nordic contexts and value chains of Circular Cities, Textile, Food Systems, and Business that catalyze the core long term goals described in A IMPACT above.

Collective project objectives. In the process of developing strategic roadmaps, all TGs aim to:

- identify and prioritize key challenges, opportunities, knowledge gaps, innovation concepts, and best practices in the industry
- identify and prioritize policy and regulatory actions, incentives, and instruments to accelerate circular transition
- explore metrics and reporting frameworks for circular performance and impact
- define a roadmap for a circular transition of the sector (key objective)
- present results at the Nordic Circular Summit and other relevant conferences and events
- promote insights and solutions as ambassadors and facilitate cross-border collaboration as change agents
- establish the group as a collaborative arena for innovation, business development, and policy beyond the project period.

Other potential outcomes. The TGs may also initiate some or several of the following:

- pilot projects to test scalable circular solutions in practice across the Nordics
- white papers, produced in close cooperation with academia, on the most pressing topics for the industry
- applications for funding additional white papers, pilots, and other spinoffs from relevant sources.

NORDIC CIRCULAR CITIES

The Transition Group for Circular Cities was launched at the Nordic Circular Summit 2024 in Helsinki.

General objectives. The purpose of this group is to accelerate circular transformation in urban areas in the Nordics by connecting municipalities, business, innovators, and capital with the aim to:

- integrate circular economy principles and realise awareness on how to secure natural, human, and social values into urban development and governance
- identify, showcase, and replicate success cases from pioneering cities such as Helsinki, Tampere, Copenhagen, and Oslo
- engage investors and financial institutions to support scalable solutions.

Project objectives. In addition to the collective project objectives (see above), this group aims to:

- define scalable and replicable models, frameworks, and methods for circular city transitions
- facilitate x-disciplinary meetings to align solution providers, problem owners, and enablers
- link start-ups and innovators with city-level transition pathways.

Partners & Stakeholders. Lead: Natural State (NO) for the NCH Consortium. Partners: Nordic Innovation, Sitra (FI), African Circular Economy Network (ACEN), INNOWO (PL), and the Environmental Impacts Academy (DK). Municipal and regional authorities: City of Helsinki, City of Tampere, City of Vantaa, City of Copenhagen, Oslo Kommune, Uusima Regional Council (FI), and Kaunas Regional Waste Management Center (LT). Private sector and start-ups: NEFCO, Kiilto Ventures, Minus Solutions (NO), Looptex (LT), Sulapac (FI), Sweco Finland, Invest-NL (NL), NOMS (SE), FundForward, Regeneration.VC (US), AFRY, Rönkä Consulting (FI), Forum Virium Helsinki, and KLAK – Icelandic Startups (IS). Business federations: NHO Service og Handel (NO), alongside links to Business Finland.

NORDIC CIRCULAR TEXTILE

The Nordic Textile Transition Group (NTT) was launched at the Nordic Circular Summit 2024 in Helsinki.

General objectives. The purpose of this group is to stimulate the circular transition in the Nordic fashion and textile sector through collaboration, knowledge sharing, and collective action with the aim to:

- integrate circular economy principles in production, consumption, and post-use systems within the sector
- identify pathways to circular design, extended producer responsibility, reuse infrastructure, and material innovation
- promote knowledge exchange across the value chain: fiber > design > production > consumption > reuse > recycling

Project objectives. In addition to the collective project objectives (see above), this group aims to:

- explore scalable and replicable models, frameworks, and methods for a circular and regenerative transition
- identify a key set of relevant and universally applicable KPIs to measure circularity for textiles
- identify potential x-Nordic collaborations/pilots between brands, startups, and researchers to accelerate innovation
- explore potential collaboration with the "Nordic-Baltic Textile Project" who has reached out to us.

Partners & Stakeholders. Lead: Lifestyle & Design Cluster (DK) for the NCH Consortium. Partners: NFTA (NO), University of Borås (SE), Sustainable Fashion Academy (SE), Finnish Fashion & Textiles (FI), Aalto University (FI), VIA Design (DK),

Royal Danish Academy (DK), Danish Fashion & Textiles (DK), Plusslab (NO). A number of other stakeholders from business, clusters, municipalities, and academia are participating. In addition we have prox 10 entrepreneurs that will be connected.

NORDIC CIRCULAR FOOD SYSTEMS

The Transition Group for Nordic Circular Food Systems is being launched during the fall of 2025.

General objectives. The purpose of this group is to gather producers, retailers, entrepreneurs, industry associations, research institutions, public stakeholders, and NGOs to collaborate on formulating concrete roadmaps, and conduct strategic implementation of action to reach the sustainable transition tipping points of the Nordic food system faster :

- *map critical food system dependencies and design pathways for reduced import reliance and increased security*
- *close nutrient and resource loops and valorize side streams, food waste, biobased residues, etc*
- *accelerate regenerative practices and climate-positive regional feed and food production adapted to Nordic conditions*
- *foster collaboration between land-based and marine food systems for integrated circularity*

Project objectives. In addition to the collective project objectives (see above), this group aims to:

- *develop policy recommendations to enable scaling of circular food systems while ensuring consumer trust*
- *identify potential pilots that reduce emissions, improve nutrition, and enhance Nordic self-sufficiency and resilience*
- *integrate nutrition, climate, and biodiversity benefits into roadmap metrics for circular food transitions*
- *assess business models that link primary production, processing, and consumption in circular loops*
- *assess "new" high-potential value chains (seaweed, alternative proteins, fermentation, upcycling of by-products, etc).*

Partners & Stakeholders. Lead: Natural State (NO) for the NCH Consortium. Partners: Centre for Circular Economy (DK), Hringrasarsetur (IS), University of Eastern Finland (FI), Norwegian University of Life Sciences (NO), and Circular Innovation Lab (DK). Companies and clusters that have been or will be invited: Swedish Cradlenet members such as AxFoundation; Norwegian HoReCa companies including Fiskeriet, Gamlebyen Mat & Drikke, and Fuglen; Natural State affiliated initiatives and active projects such as Vesterålen local foods, Ravnedalen Live, and Biosirk; innovative SMEs like Smartsoil (NO) and Volare (FI); the Iceland Ocean Cluster (IS); Nalik Ventures (GL); the Ministry of the Environment, Faroe Islands; BIO (NO) through Ivar Horneland Kristiansen; and Linköping University (SE) via Professor Mattias Lindahl. Large industry players such as Tine, Nortura, Arla, Orkla Foods, Lantmännen, Rema 1000, and Norgesgruppen have also been identified as relevant demand-side stakeholders.

NORDIC CIRCULAR BUSINESS TRANSITION - CORPORATE CIRCULAR TRANSITION

The Transition Group for Corporate Circular Transition will be launched during the fall of 2025.

General objectives. The purpose of this group is to accelerate corporate circular transition with the aim to:

- *integrate circular principles into corporate strategy, business models, and operations*
- *define actionable pathways to integrate circularity into product design, supply chains, and services*
- *reduce corporate environmental and climate footprints by closing material and resource loops.*

Project objectives. In addition to the collective project objectives (see above), this group aims to:

- *explore scalable models, frameworks, and methods for an incremental systemic corporate circular transition*
- *map innovative business models that shift from ownership to service, performance, or access models*
- *identify and prioritize actions to strengthen competitiveness, innovation capacity, and resilience*
- *assess how corporate procurement can accelerate circularity across value chains*
- *map enablers for scaling such as digital tools, design for reuse and remanufacturing, logistics, reverse flows, etc.*

Partners & Stakeholders. Lead: Cradlenet (SE) as lead partner for the NCH Consortium. Partners: the following stakeholders are considered for invitation. Industry associations: Avfall Sverige (SE), Sirk Norge (NO), Avfald Danmark (DK), Brancheforeningen Cirkulær (DK), KIVO (FI), JHY (FI), Återvinningsindustrierna (SE), ARI Affalds- og resource-industrien (DK), Kierrätysteollisuus ry (FI). Trade organizations: Dansk Industri (DK), Norsk Industri (NO), EK Elinkeino-elämän Keskusliitto (FI), Svenskt Näringsliv (SE), Teknikföretagen (SE). Other stakeholders: Industriens Fond (DK), RE:Source (SE), Helsinki Circular Valley (FI), Nordic Working Group for Circular Economy, NCCE (NO), Nefco, Cleantech Finland (FI), Demos Helsinki (FI). Companies: Atlas Copco, Boliden AB, Equinor, Foxway, Kone, Novo Nordisk, Outokumpu, Posti, Ragn-Sells, Skanska, Scania + a number of others for a representative cross-sectoral representation.

ANNEX 3 # ACTION PLAN

CONTINUOUS			
WP1	TG # Circular Cities	recruit and engage relevant stakeholders	M03
WP1	TG # Circular Cities	define a contextually relevant plan for activities within the TG	M04
WP1	TG # Circular Cities	execute workshops and other relevant activities	M05
WP1	TG # Circular Cities	write a strategic roadmap that summarizes key insights	M06
WP1	TG # Circular Cities	publish the roadmap and present results in public online event	M07
WP1	TG # Circular Cities	discuss possible next steps and make plan for further action	M08
WP2	TG # Corporate Circularity	recruit and engage relevant stakeholders	M09
WP2	TG # Corporate Circularity	define a contextually relevant plan for activities within the TG	M10
WP2	TG # Corporate Circularity	execute workshops and other relevant activities	M11
WP2	TG # Corporate Circularity	write a strategic roadmap that summarizes key insights	M12
WP2	TG # Corporate Circularity	publish the roadmap and present results in public online event	M13
WP2	TG # Corporate Circularity	discuss possible next steps and make plan for further action	M14
WP3	TG # Circular Food	recruit and engage relevant stakeholders	M15
WP3	TG # Circular Food	define a contextually relevant plan for activities within the TG	M16
WP3	TG # Circular Food	execute workshops and other relevant activities	M17
WP3	TG # Circular Food	write a strategic roadmap that summarizes key insights	M18
WP3	TG # Circular Food	publish the roadmap and present results in public online event	M19
WP3	TG # Circular Food	discuss possible next steps and make plan for further action	M20
WP4	TG # Circular Textile	recruit and engage relevant stakeholders	M21
WP4	TG # Circular Textile	define a contextually relevant plan for activities within the TG	M22
WP4	TG # Circular Textile	execute workshops and other relevant activities	M23
WP4	TG # Circular Textile	write a strategic roadmap that summarizes key insights	M24
WP4	TG # Circular Textile	publish the roadmap and present results in public online event	M25
WP4	TG # Circular Textile	discuss possible next steps and make plan for further action	M26
WP5	Communications	included in WP1–WP4 above	M25
WP6	Administration	biweekly meetings	M26
WP6	Administration	continuous administration	M27
WP6	Administration	continuous support of the TGs	M28

Oslo 2025-06-25



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